The Future White: Selective Reproductive Ideals and the Continuity of Settler Rule

Manuscript status: Research draft for hypothetical external submission, NOT submitted or peer reviewed. Author credit and permission to quote the originating client's private research statement are unresolved; neither the client's name nor the private statement appears in this manuscript. Historical documents and already published works are identified in references. Further archival checks and independent review are specified below.

Candidate journal: Settler Colonial Studies (research article). The journal accepts original interdisciplinary articles on settler colonialism and uses double-anonymized review. Target is a defensible conceptual and documentary historical intervention, not a quantitative causal estimate.

Abstract

The expression white increase appears to describe a population growing through births and migration, but settler institutions have also used it to defend a restricted ideal of legitimate reproduction and a political order capable of surviving changes in the people designated white. How can a regime invoke the survival of a population while rendering some of its existing members unfit to reproduce that population? This article distinguishes three operations: numerical increase among a historically classified people; the attempted production of an ideal future group through selective eligibility; and reproduction of property and territorial rule. A focused documentary comparison of Benjamin Franklin's 1751 population arithmetic, early twentieth-century race-suicide and eugenic pronatalism, and Virginia's racial-integrity legislation of 1924 and subsequent revision efforts demonstrates that numerical increase and purity were neither identical nor uniformly prioritized. Virginia's ancestry exception, defended and subsequently widened to protect favored social positions, is particularly revealing: proclaimed purity could be relaxed when rigid application endangered the standing of influential people. Read with recent histories of settler sociology and of racialized reproductive expropriation, the findings support a model of conditional selective futurity, not a prediction of white biological disappearance. The paper specifies what additional cohort and institutional evidence would be necessary to test the stronger conjecture that an imagined ideal is pursued at the expense of the existing population's reproductive continuity.

Keywords: settler colonialism; racial classification; social reproduction; eugenics; whiteness; reproductive futurity; migration; racial-integrity law.

1. A population that is not yet the imagined population

The white settler has sometimes been presented as a present proprietor, an heir, and the bearer of a demographic future. Each description depends upon a different operation. A proprietor obtains a protected claim through law; an heir is recognized within a kinship and succession regime; a demographic future is produced through birth, survival, marriage, migration, and care. Yet these processes have frequently been represented under a single name: the increase or preservation of the white population. Conflating them prevents historical inquiry into situations where one operation contradicts another.

Consider a conditional proposition. Suppose an ideological regime claims that what really deserves to reproduce is not the present population classified white but an exceptional hereditary type that the population has not yet produced. The regime may treat actual people as inputs to a search for a future population whose founding conditions remain unfulfilled.

Its promised reproductive future can then become a reason to exclude, sterilize, impoverish, deport, or dispossess people otherwise assigned white status. The strongest version predicts that the human material sustaining the search may be exhausted before its imagined success condition is achieved. This is a question about the revealed priorities and temporality of governing institutions, not a biological claim that whiteness denotes a natural human subspecies.

That formulation forces two distinctions. First, wanting fewer births among a politically stigmatized subset is not the same as actually driving a whole classified population toward disappearance. Second, preserving the rules of a settler state may require neither preserving every person recognized as white nor creating a more genetically ideal white person. The organization of land, labor, credit, household security, and citizenship may continue even when the population categories attached to those relations change.

This article interrogates the more modest and historically tractable proposition: when numerical reproduction and a selective ideal conflicted, which element did settler institutions preserve? It asks this across several specifically dated texts and laws. The study does not assume that a single actor called whiteness makes decisions, nor that its doctrines remain unchanged for centuries. The object is a set of institutions, claims, and decisions that can be compared without anthropomorphizing a racial category.

2. Literature, argument, and the difference from existing research

Patrick Wolfe's account of settler colonialism as an enduring structure directs attention from initial conquest to mechanisms repeatedly securing the settler's claim to replace Indigenous polities. That is crucial, but a state gaining territory, a household securing inheritance, and a population having children are not interchangeable outcomes (Wolfe 2006). Jennifer L. Morgan demonstrates that the very ability to turn kinship and childbirth into commodities was constitutive of racialized Atlantic capitalism (Morgan 2021). Hortense Spillers describes how the juridical form of hereditary slavery reorganized the language of kinship rather than simply denying enslaved people the capacity to make families (Spillers 1987). These studies caution against taking the census's racial categories as self-evident biological groups.

Anna Stubblefield shows that eugenic judgments could define some ostensibly white people as tainted through intersections of disability, poverty, ethnicity, sex, and gendered moral expectations (Stubblefield 2007). Simone Caron traces how advocates of race suicide simultaneously promoted births by those judged fit and discouraged or prohibited births by those judged unfit (Caron 2008). Here the alleged preservation of a race already entailed differential reproductive value within the privileged category.

Two very recent contributions sharpen the need for a distinct claim. Musab Younis reconstructs demographic science in the history of settler rule and traces the reversal whereby dominant populations figure themselves as threatened by replacement (Younis 2026). Heidi Nicholls directly shows that early U.S. sociologists advanced both exclusionary purity and assimilationist/amalgamationist forms of eugenic social planning to stabilize the settler state (Nicholls 2026). It would therefore be neither novel nor defensible to announce simply that eugenics was colonial or that purity and amalgamation were competing colonial strategies.

The specific contribution attempted here is instead an inquiry into which objective is sacrificed when the demands are inconsistent. A purity ratchet is only one possible causal process. The same institution may relax its imagined standard to preserve the status of an established elite; it may broaden incorporation to stabilize settler claims; it may pursue hereditary exclusion while drawing labor from people denied membership; or it may be indifferent to the ability of ordinary classified whites to reproduce. A priority ordering inferred from decisions under pressure is a more discriminating object than an abstract

assertion that every racial regime seeks an impossible final type.

3. Sources and method

The evidentiary design is qualitative comparative historical process tracing. The core documents are: (a) Franklin's Observations Concerning the Increase of Mankind (1751), sections 1-3 and 23-24; (b) Roosevelt's letter to Charles Davenport of 3 January 1913 and Scott Nearing's 1911 public debate over race suicide; (c) Virginia's enacted Preservation of Racial Integrity (1924), including the specific Indigenous-ancestry exception; and (d) the subsequent Virginia legislative revision history as reconstructed by Virginia Humanities, checked against the exact wording of the 1924 statute. The comparison is purposive: each source exposes a tension between a demographic objective and a rule of privileged membership. This is not a probability sample of settlers or a representative census of eugenic policymakers.

Original full-text versions of Franklin's essay, the Roosevelt letter, and the 1924 statute are available through scholarly or archival transcriptions. The present draft has checked the original wording reproduced on those surfaces. The fine-grained 1926 legislative chronology is taken from the scholarly historical synthesis published by Virginia Humanities and remains to be cross-checked against the House and Senate journals, original bill versions, and committee records before external submission. Nicholls's 2026 article was read from the full open-access publisher text; relevant books are used at the level explicitly available through their publisher records and prior Sociology bibliography, without claiming close reading of unavailable chapters.

For each case, the analytical columns are: the stated future being protected; the population counted as entitled to that future; the eligibility criterion; the people whose reproduction or membership would be denied; the institution capable of enforcing the rule; and the observed revision when a rule conflicted with a valuable social position. A documented statement of ideology is evidence of an intention or aspiration, not evidence of an enacted policy or resulting demographic outcome. That restriction is central to the method.

Three rival explanations are retained. Numerical natalism predicts priority for increasing actual white-classified births. Uncompromising purity selection predicts persistence or tightening of ancestry standards even when large numbers of otherwise privileged people lose membership. Institutional status preservation predicts revision, exception, or selective accommodation when purity threatens groups whose recognized position the governing order depends upon. These are ideal-type predictions; actual laws may express more than one.

4. Franklin: the arithmetic of settlement and the limits of counting

Franklin's 1751 essay begins by distinguishing demographic patterns in saturated towns from those in lands where household formation is easier. The available means of subsistence, the cost of forming a family, and opportunities to marry are central determinants of natural increase in the essay's opening reasoning. Franklin also says some cities do not naturally replace their residents because deaths exceed births. This insight already complicates any attempt to treat the reproduction of a polity as equivalent to births within each of its settlements. Towns may persist through immigration even when local vital rates are insufficient.

But in the same essay Franklin describes colonial settlement as a means of expanding a preferred population, then narrows the meaning of white to a select group of Europeans. In sections 23-24, the wish to increase those he regards as white exists alongside hostility toward immigrants from many other European populations and toward the importation of Africans. His category is strikingly narrower than later official or popular versions of whiteness. Thus

a policy can simultaneously favor more settlers, oppose particular sources of immigration, value greater births, and refuse to count substantial populations as desirable contributors to the racial future.

The significant tension is not that Franklin openly proposed extinguishing the population he favored. He did not. It is that his increase was selective from its earliest expression. The target of expansion was an institutionally chosen kind of population, not every person later to be described as white. The surrounding population could expand even as the imagined deserving subset remained selectively drawn. Franklin's model of growth depends on available land and livelihoods, and the text's confidence in colonial expansion presupposes the settler's territorial claim. The Indigenous inhabitants whose political relations were displaced by that claim are not interchangeable with omitted census observations.

The demographic lesson must remain bounded. Nineteenth-century U.S. growth was largely the result of natural increase; Haines (1994) estimates very high U.S. fertility around 1800, and Haines's historical components series assigns most growth in 1790-1860 to births exceeding deaths, rather than net international migration. Franklin's statement about particular towns cannot be converted into a claim that the whole country, or all its white-classified population, was incapable of replacing itself without migration. Instead the essay supplies an early analytic distinction between local reproduction, migration-supported settlement, the distribution of land and household resources, and which settlers an elite wished to count.

5. Race suicide: an ideal with two incompatible directives

By the early twentieth century, the rhetoric of race suicide announced demographic crisis in a different register. Roosevelt's 1913 letter to eugenicist Charles Davenport condemns the reproduction of people he calls defective while demanding more children from citizens he deems properly suited to reproduce. The livestock analogy in the letter is deliberate; the imagined future depends upon distinguishing acceptable and unacceptable parenthood. A recognized citizen is no longer necessarily a desirable reproducer.

The empirical meaning is more exact than "white supremacists wanted fewer white people." Roosevelt sought more births among the favored group and fewer among those he stigmatized. The question is whether the exclusion rule would have the effect of reducing the size or viability of the very population the institution said it wished to maintain. An answer requires the size, age structure, and fertility of the excluded subgroup, the effects of imposed policy relative to available alternatives, and countervailing natalist interventions. A letter cannot establish any of those effects.

Scott Nearing's 1911 essay intervened against the prevailing population alarm by distinguishing the sheer number of children from the supposedly improved quality of the population. The merits of that alleged quality are not granted here. The relevance is that historical contemporaries could themselves articulate a conflict between maximizing numbers and selecting a favored future. The contestation was therefore not an accidental contradiction discovered only after the fact; it was an explicit argumentative divide.

Caron's history of race-suicide and contraception and Stubblefield's analysis of "tainted whiteness" document the social conditions through which such a divide could become action. A purportedly white woman might be disqualified from bearing a legitimate reproductive future because of poverty, disability, ethnicity, perceived sexual misconduct, or institutional classification. The political category thus contains an internal frontier. But the frontier is not necessarily a mechanical ratchet: the state may encourage more births among an elite or change the categories themselves. The causal question is not simply whether exclusion happened but how much reproduction and freedom it suppressed, at whose initiative, and in defense of what institutionally valuable outcome.

6. Virginia: purity, exception, and the preservation of elite identity

Virginia's 1924 Preservation of Racial Integrity offers a more discriminating test than retrospective inferences from sterilization totals. The enacted text prohibited a person classified white from marrying anyone except someone classified white, with a defined exception for people said to have up to one-sixteenth American Indian ancestry and no other non-Caucasian ancestry. In another provision, the state simultaneously claimed to be establishing a categorical racial standard without mixture. The political rule was therefore inconsistent with a simple literal instruction never to admit a trace of nonwhite ancestry.

The inconsistency was not a merely statistical flaw. Virginia Humanities documents debate around the exception, including concern among established white Virginians claiming descent from Pocahontas. When eligibility rules threatened elite reputations and family status, the rules were revised to accommodate those claims. A 1926 proposal to remove the exception was subsequently amended in the House to permit up to one-eighth American Indian ancestry, broader than the one-sixteenth exception in the 1924 law (Encyclopedia Virginia, "Racial Integrity Laws, 1924-1930"). The historical record of the 1926 proposal and amendments must not be confused with the exact final effect of every subsequent enacted statute; those are distinct legislative states requiring a complete bill history.

This case sharply differentiates purity as an absolute reproductive endpoint from purity as a negotiable legal technology of belonging. When the rule threatened to disqualify valued white identities, a social coalition could preserve those identities by rewriting the rule. The imagined standard was sacrificed-or selectively suspended-to preserve an already established elite. That does not make the practice benign: restrictions on Black and Indigenous familial recognition and the violent bureaucratic erasure of Indigenous identities persisted. The exception protected one group's inclusion within whiteness while the system continued dispossessing and misclassifying others.

There is consequently a counterexample to an unqualified claim of monotonically intensifying purity. At least some influential participants had both the leverage and incentive to broaden a boundary that endangered their standing. The material object reproduced was their membership and the credibility of inherited superiority, not numerical equality for all residents or consistent application of a genetic principle.

This observation does not prove that reproductive selection generally failed, nor that elites always protected all people classified white. It shows why a serious theory of white self-consumption must specify whose reproduction is sacrificed and which privileges are preserved. A state may make ordinary people expendable while preserving a narrowly situated class. The alternative hypothesis of elite-status reproduction can thus account for behavior otherwise misread as a desperate attempt to create an impossible biologically pure population.

7. Settler sociology: purity and assimilation are competing solutions

Nicholls's examination of early U.S. sociologists provides a further negative control. The racial projects of Earnest Sevier Cox and Robert Park did not pursue a single progressively narrower boundary. In Nicholls's reconstruction, Cox defended segregation, expulsion, and racial purity as necessary to imperial stability, while Park and associates considered assimilation and amalgamation ways to secure loyalty and order. Their positions were inconsistent concerning who should reproduce and join the polity, yet compatible in naturalizing the settler state's authority over Indigenous lands (Nicholls 2026).

The significance is institutional, not a claim that Cox and Park had identical intentions. If the desired end were simply the preservation of a biologically isolated white population, the assimilationist approach would be unintelligible. If the shared end were stabilization of the

settler state, distinct policies could become rival means toward that end. The position of actual inhabitants relative to state categories could change without equivalent changes in births, deaths or genetic ancestry.

This is the point at which the client's limiting image acquires its strongest historical use. The pursuit of a future supposedly worthy of reproduction can be indefinitely deferred or redefined because the political institution need not realize that future in order to continue. Its day-to-day reproduction may instead depend on property law, bureaucracy, territorial rule, extracted labor, and the replacement of one population classification by another. A claim that the ideal will eventually be embodied need not ever become a measurable production target for the institution to benefit politically from it.

8. Captive increase: reproduction of property without reproduction of inclusion

This does not mean white settlers' own births ceased to matter. Indeed, the historical evidence contradicts a generalized claim of nineteenth-century national demographic incapacity. The more profound discontinuity is that one population's reproduction could generate legal wealth and governing power for others without granting corresponding membership.

The 1662 Virginia rule of hereditary enslavement assigned a child's legal condition through the mother. It permitted the enslaver's property claim to extend into descendants; later slave law could capitalize the future "increase" of enslaved women as a transferable interest. Morgan (2021), Spillers (1987), and Alphonso's explicitly non-peer-reviewed 2023 paper approach the relation among reproduction, kinship and value from different historical and conceptual directions. Their distinctions matter. The legal expropriation of reproduction is not evidence that every pregnancy resulted from a deliberately organized "breeding farm." Enslaved people sustained family relationships and actively resisted the regime; neither the statistical observation of births nor the ownership claim exhausts the meaning of those lives.

Within the slaveholding order, a child's birth could increase an owner's expected labor resources and property claims even though the child lacked the civil status associated with white settler descent. Consequently a historical inquiry restricted to births counted as white would miss a central mechanism sustaining the social order claiming to represent white settlers. Conversely, counting births into slavery as if they proved a purposive program of manufacturing white "super specimens" would confuse separate mechanisms and historical periods.

A companion demographic research note uses Hacker's historical estimates of births into slavery and Haines-Sutch's national-birth reconstructions to calculate the proportion of counted births entering the system of hereditary bondage in 1790-1849 and 1790-1859. Those figures measure the scale of the captive reproductive generation, not the causal contribution of those births to every form of settler wealth or political power. An eventual historical-economic study would have to connect particular births and property claims to probate, price, collateral, succession, and institutional representation. The conceptual contribution here is the nonidentity of reproducing people, classifying legitimate descendants, and reproducing colonial property and rule.

9. What the original limit case would require as an empirical claim

We can now specify why the proposition that the system would consume every ordinary white person before finding two ideal progenitors is not yet an established historical finding. Let the first clock denote the amount of time required for an institution to reach its own,

historically specific criterion for a legitimate reproducing founder set. Let the second clock denote the remaining supported reproductive continuity of an actual defined population or cohort. A claim that the second clock runs out first is meaningful only if both conditions have observable criteria.

A retrospective researcher must therefore recover explicit eligibility standards and their historical revisions; identify real feasible policy alternatives; observe which subsets bore the cost of rejected parenthood, impoverishment, mortality, displacement, or coercive treatment; and calculate the relevant cohorts' continued childbearing and survival. Racial category changes and migration may alter the size of the counted population without any corresponding change in biological reproduction. Without these observations, predicting disappearance is a rhetorical extrapolation.

Moreover, the institutions are heterogeneous. A court protecting an old family's "white" identity may relax a rule, a reproductive health bureaucracy may intensify exclusion, and employers may degrade the living conditions of ordinary white workers for reasons of accumulation not reducible to eugenics. If these processes simply coexist, treating them as the intentional acts of one selecting entity is an invalid causal inference. Evidence of shared finance, authority, ideology, and decision-making is required to say they form a common operational system.

Three propositions have different evidence statuses:

Observed historically: settlers and state actors sought population growth while specifying who was entitled to reproduce their political-racial future; exclusionary and assimilationist policies both served state continuity; the strictness of a legal whiteness rule could be relaxed for privileged people.

Mechanistically plausible: some institutions valued the reproduction of status, property and authority more than the continuity of all persons assigned white status; other people's reproductive labor could materially sustain that order.

Not established: a self-reinforcing purity search that drove any entire white-classified population to demographic extinction before achieving a concrete hereditary ideal.

A theory that cannot distinguish these claims will either flatten the client's hypothesis into trivial eugenic exclusion or present a dramatic outcome it has not demonstrated.

10. Conclusion

The central problem of white increase is not necessarily a contradiction between a group's birthrate and an externally imposed population. It is a contradiction among projects that call themselves the reproduction of whiteness. Franklin's narrowly defined preferred settlers, the early twentieth-century distinction between proper and improper reproducers, and Virginia's protection of elite membership through an ancestry exception show that numerical population, legitimate reproductive futures and institutional status have never been synonymous. Nicholls's account of both exclusionary and assimilationist settler sociology shows that a still broader objective-the continuation of colonial rule-can survive competing reproductive prescriptions.

The evidence presently supports an institutional rather than biological conclusion. The future presented as worthy of reproduction may be repeatedly redefined while the existing people are governed, classified, exploited or deprived in its name. The strongest version, that ordinary reproductive continuity is exhausted before the alleged ideal is ever produced, remains an explicit hypothesis requiring measured cohorts and policy-linked counterfactuals. It should not be mistaken for an inevitable demographic forecast.

This shifts the research question away from who will count as the last white descendants and toward who has the authority to defer the promised future, who is made to bear the costs of that deferral, and which institutions successfully reproduce themselves without delivering what their reproductive ideology promises.

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Commission-specific source critical receiving

The annotated bibliography and claim-to-evidence crosswalk connects the manuscript's claims to currently held source annotations (WI-01-WI-23). Readers should consult those rather than treating the number of works cited as a proof of the argument. The original commission dossier, historical demographic-estimand note, and captive reproduction source-criticism note retain methodological disagreements and the client-derived inquiry without reauthoring its original statement.

Crucial prior scholarship not to misclaim as original: Cheryl I. Harris (1993), Whiteness as Property, established the juridical-property account of whiteness; Heidi Nicholls (2026) demonstrates both segregating and amalgamating eugenic settler sociology, while Musab Younis (2026) traces demography's colonial political genealogy. The manuscript's proposed contribution is the different question of revealed preference when actual subjects' generational continuity, imagined future reproductive legitimacy, and elite/property continuity conflict. The evidence so far demonstrates the contradiction's intelligibility, not that a whole white-classified population was historically sacrificed unto extinction.

Virginia legislative boundary: The 1924 enacted law contained the one-sixteenth Indigenous ancestry exception; a 1926 House proposal sought and obtained an amendment expanding it to one-eighth. The Senate indefinitely postponed that proposal. It was a meaningful contested legislative preference, not an enacted replacement for the 1924 law. The history must also attend to the dispossession of Indigenous identity and community recognition and Arica L. Coleman's Black-Indigenous histories; white elite family status was not the sole harmed or protected interest.

Materiality and demographic counterevidence: Haines and Hacker (2006) report a declining white child-woman ratio in 1800-1860, but Hacker (2003) dates the onset of reconstructed fertility decline differently. Hacker, Haines and Jaremski (2021) compare explanations using complete-count censuses; these are competing estimator designs, not proof that purifying ideology caused demographic shortfall. The direct coerced reproduction study by Djeliid (2024) and Virginia's 1662 statute concern different but materially connected mechanisms by which actual existing lives reproduced slaveholding property, kinship harm and labor.

Additional substantive sources requiring review before submission

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Declarations and review boundary

Data availability: All cited original-text and research materials are referenced by stable URLs. The companion demographic dataset and independently executable Engineering reader reside in the 561 Group's private source corpus. No confidential client quotation or identifying information is reproduced in this manuscript.

Ethics: Documentary historical analysis only; no human-subject recruitment or identifiable private participant data. Formal ethical assessment has not been obtained and must be decided by the actual author/institution if submitted.

Funding and conflicts: Not ascertained. No assertion of absence is made on behalf of the eventual authors.

Authorship: To be settled with the research client; this drafting assistant is not assigned human authorship. No journal submission has occurred.

Before hypothetical submission: Independently verify the exact 1926 bill and amendment chronology in primary legislative records; reread cited scholarly works in full where only publisher materials have been inspected; cross-check original full-text quotations and source licenses; obtain the client's account of their original proposition; solicit a domain-expert assessment of originality against Nicholls (2026) and Younis (2026); and perform double-anonymous manuscript preparation. These are real outstanding scholarly requirements, not merely formatting tasks.